# You are Who You Choose to Be

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora (She-Ra), Kesi (Defiance), Original Female Character(s), Original Male Character(s), Original Trans Character(s)

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# You are Who You Choose to Be

by tp9829, Zelenal

Summary

Adora gets her proper introduction to cave culture.

- Inspired by Defiance by TheNotebookWizard

**The High Temple**

**Halfmoon**

**Subtheria**

***One Year After the Coup Attempt***

"Hey, Kesi, can I ask you a question?" Adora asked one day as she and Kesi were finishing up their chores for the day. It had been about a year since that faithful day that led to Adora being brought to Halfmoon and she had been adjusting quite nicely, as far as Kesi was concerned. There was more than a little culture shock at first but Adora had adapted surprisingly quickly. Even when it was revealed that she had celestial magic, she had taken it in stride.

"Of course, Adora. You can ask me anything," Kesi replied with a smile. She found that she rather liked this strange little girl; she was a surprisingly warm and gentle person for someone who spent the first few years of her life in the Horde.

"How come your jewelry and clothes are so different from basically everyone else's?" she asked with a quizzical tilt of her head that was distinctly Magicat in nature (Adora seemed to be picking up quite a number of Magicat social quirks which wasn't surprising).

Kesi's smile widened. "That's because they're a part of cave culture." Knowing Adora's likely followup question, Kesi continued, "Cave culture is a small culture created by people like me who were born in the caves and don't really care about going back to the surface."

"You don't want to go back to the surface?"

"Not really," Kesi replied with a shake of her head. She and Adora moved over to one of the pews to sit down. "The caves

have taken really good care of us and we've adapted to living in them. Why would we want to go to a place that not even our parents have been to?"

Adora hummed in thought for a moment; Kesi found her serious thinking expression to be rather cute. "That makes sense. You guys aren't really missing out on anything anyway; Halfmoon is *way* better than anything up there!"

Kesi beamed at the younger girl as a pleased purr rumbled to life in her chest. This, as was almost always the case, triggered Adora's own sort of purr (Kesi *still* couldn't get over the fact that Adora could do that).

"I'm glad you think so," Kesi said warmly.

Adora stopped her sort of purr to talk. "So, what's cave culture all about?"

"It's about a lot of things," Kesi began, "but, most importantly, it's about being you. It's about being unashamed of who you are and reveling in it. It's about celebrating all of the things that make us different from each other. It's about acceptance and love and being who you choose to be."

Adora went all starry-eyed partway through Kesi's explanation. "How do you join? I wanna join! Can I join?"

Kesi giggled. "Of course you can! And you don't really join, you just… *be.* But we *do* have clothes and customs associated with us. We can get you some cave culture clothes and maybe some jewelry if you want."

"Yes, please!" Adora said as she grabbed Kesi by the hand and all but bolted to her room, nearly dragging Kesi with her. Kesi couldn't help but giggle again at Adora's boundless excitement.

This was going to be fun!

**The Waxing Market**

**Halfmoon**

**Subtheria**

***One Year After the Coup Attempt***

Kesi led Adora through the streets of Halfmoon, turning this way and that, following a path that she knew by heart. She was taking the younger girl to a particular marketplace that she frequented that was almost exclusively cave culture, seeing as how almost nothing like that could be found in the Crescent Market.

As they came onto the main street of the marketplace, Adora gasped. While it wasn't *nearly* as grand as the Crescent Market, the vibe was *completely* different. They weren't so much storefronts as there were stalls—some owned by one person or group and others basically rented out. The place was fairly busy at this time of day and, as such, Adora was getting a *massive* exposure to cave culture fashion.

"Welcome to the center of cave culture commerce, Adora! While this place *technically* doesn't have an official name, everyone calls it the Waxing Market," Kesi said as she gestured with her free hand (the other was holding one of Adora's).

"This is *amazing!"* Adora said with starry-eyed wonder. They—or, rather, Adora—were attracting a bit of attention since Adora *always* attracted attention for obvious reasons but it was all positive: people smiling and waving or calling out greetings. "Why's it called that?" she asked as she smiled and waved back.

"'Waxing' refers to one of the phases of the moons just like 'crescent' does. We chose it because we like to think of ourselves as growing into, well, ourselves as people but also into our life in the caves and our influence on Halfmoon's culture in general," Kesi explained. "So, Adora, where do you want to start?"

Adora hummed in thought as she looked around before looking back at Kesi. “Can we start with jewelry?” she asked.

Kesi smiled. “Of course! Do you want to start with rings, bracelets, or earrings?”

Adora thought for a moment longer before saying, “Earrings! Yours are *really* pretty!”

Kesi’s smile grew that much larger. “Thank you! We’ll start you out with only two, though—one for each ear—so that way you can get used to them. I also know *just* the guy to do it. Come on!”

Kesi led Adora through the throng of people, greeting anyone she passed who she knew in the process. It only took a couple minutes before they came to the stall Kesi was looking for.

The stall had a wide variety of jewelry on display that Kesi knew was made by the stallholder and his friends. Said stallholder was a male Magicat of decent height with midnight black fur that made his blue eyes stand out and a dark brown mane that was intricately braided.

He was wearing a navy blue sash that tied into a belt at the waist to help hold up a vibrant red half skirt, his modesty being “protected” for the sake of most of Halfmoon by a similarly colored short loincloth. A silver chain crossed the sash going from his other shoulder to his hip where it was woven into the belt.

As for jewelry, his ears were pierced in five places with a combination of rings, studs, and a single gauge while his mane had colorful beads and ribbons weaved into it. Filigree cuffs made from silver and copper decorated his arms and tail and his belly button was pierced with a gold ring. Lastly, his sheathed claws were painted silver and seemed to sparkle in the light.

“Kesi! It’s good to see you again, my friend!” He greeted her as he got up from where he had been sitting on the ground to walking around his wares before crouching down slightly to envelop Kesi in a hug.

"It's good to see you, too, Fireheart!" Kesi replied as she gladly returned the hug. When Fireheart stepped back, Kesi gestured to Adora. "This is Adora!"

"Should I hug him, too?" Adora asked Kesi.

"If you want," Kesi answered as Fireheart crouched down and held his arms open. Adora almost immediately practically tackled him in a fierce hug, causing Fireheart to laugh while Kesi giggled.

"So, this is the Etherian girl who King Cyrus saved that I've been hearing so much about. She's going to fit right in!" Fireheart said as he let go of Adora and stood up. "What can I get you two lovely ladies?" he asked as he circled back around his goods and sat down again.

"I wanna get earrings like you and Kesi!" Adora said as she threw her arms up, evidently unable to contain her excitement.

Fireheart laughed again. "That's the spirit, little one!" He looked up at Kesi. "Are you getting her piercings or clip-ons?"

"Piercings. Just one in each ear and we're going to do small loops," Kesi answered.

"Smart choice, smart choice. Just one moment." Fireheart reached back to grab his large pack and began digging through it. "I know I have some in here somewhere… Aha!" He pulled out a box roughly the size of his forearm and presented it proudly.

"These," Fireheart began, addressing Adora, "are all of the loop earrings I have for little ones like you. They're nothing fancy but you should start out simple to get used to them as you're growing. Make sense?"

"Yeah," Adora said with a firm nod. "It's like training a muscle, right? You gotta start out easy so that way you don't hurt yourself."

Fireheart laughed again. "That's *exactly* right! You're a clever one, aren't you?" Adora positively preened at the praise. Not for the first time, Kesi was stricken by how such simple praise made Adora beam with pride. "Go ahead and pick out your favorite. You can take your time; I'm not planning on closing up shop for the next couple hours."

**The Waxing Market**

**Halfmoon**

**Subtheria**

***One Year After the Coup Attempt***

It took a few minutes but Adora eventually chose which ones she wanted—small, silver-plated hoops—and she had her ears pierced right then and there. Kesi was amazed and more than a little concerned by the fact that Adora didn't even so much as blink when the needle had gone through.

After that was done, Adora had decided that she wanted to look at clothes next so they spent the next hour or so going from stall to stall, letting Adora look at and even try on certain clothes that fight her or could easily be taken in. It wasn't unusual for cave culture people to try on just shy of anything right then and there without going someplace out-of-sight to change (they'd do it for literally every article of clothing if it weren't for the fact that non-cave culture people where sometimes present and might have problems). Adora, likely thanks to the magic of being a little kid, had absolutely no issue following suit, much to the delight of the stallholders and odd shopkeeper.

When all was said and done, Adora had three new outfits and several pieces of jewelry while Kesi had two new outfits of her own (Adora had a sizeable stipend provided by the royal family which Kesi had charged Adora's things to while she paid for her

own things [even though Adora *had* wanted to pay for them "herself"]).

Adora was now wearing a gold chest wrap made from a soft fabric with two silver sashes forming an X crossing over her front and back before tying into a belt. While she had tried on a number of different bottoms, she found that she liked pants and things adjacent to them more than skirts (with the exception of half skirts which she thought looked cool but none of those were made for kids). As such, she wore billowing silver-white pants made from an airy fabric.

As for jewelry, aside from her earrings, she had gotten a jade bracelet with matching anklet (each worn on opposite sides of the body, of course) and a silver-white ribbon to keep her hair tied back in her signature ponytail.

"Hey, Adora," Kesi began after they finished eating a late lunch, "do you have an idea as to who you want to be? You're answer's not set in stone; you can change it however many times you like whenever you like."

Adora hummed in thought again as the pair started to make their way back to the High Temple. "I wanna be someone who can protect the people I care about. People like you and Catra!"

Kesi couldn't help her pleased purr which, as always, triggered Adora's own sort of purr (Kesi had to bite back a laugh at the startled reactions of those around them at hearing it—it *never* got old). "I'm sure that you'll do a *wonderful* job at that," Kesi said with all of the sincerity in her heart.

Kesi didn't know what the future would hold but, as she watched Adora run ahead of her and laughed as she chased after her, she knew one thing with absolute certainty:

Adora was going to change everything.

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